JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 4: Health & Emergency Awareness

Module 9 - Healthcare Services & Medical Rights

Module Overview

India's healthcare system offers far more to citizens than most people realise — free government schemes, legal patient rights, and life-saving donation systems that quietly work every day. This handbook is Module 9 of JanGyan's Health & Emergency Awareness category, and it helps every citizen navigate this system confidently, from the local health centre to a major hospital.

By the end of this handbook, you will understand how India's healthcare system is structured, how Ayushman Bharat and health insurance actually work, how to access ambulance services, how blood and organ donation save lives, what rights you hold as a patient, and which helplines to call in every situation. This module is designed as a complete, self-sufficient guide.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Describe India's primary, secondary, and tertiary healthcare structure.
- Compare government and private hospital care confidently.
- Explain the basics of health insurance and key terms used.
- Understand who is eligible for Ayushman Bharat and what it covers.
- Know how to access ambulance services quickly in an emergency.
- Understand the basics of safe blood and organ donation in India.
- Recognise your rights as a patient at any healthcare facility.
- Recall India's most important health helpline numbers.

Why This Topic Matters

Important

Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY now covers over 12 crore families with more than 42 crore Ayushman cards issued — yet many eligible citizens still don't know they qualify, or don't know how to use their entitlement when it matters most.

A citizen who understands how the healthcare system works — what's free, what their rights are, and who to call — is far better protected than one who only learns during a crisis. This handbook exists to make that knowledge available in advance, not after an emergency has already begun.

Introduction

India's healthcare system runs through a mix of government and private institutions, supported by national insurance schemes and legally recognised patient rights.

Definition

Healthcare Access refers to a citizen's practical ability to obtain timely, affordable, and appropriate medical care — which depends not only on nearby facilities, but also on awareness of entitlements, insurance, and rights.

This handbook walks through that entire system — from your nearest primary health centre to a major tertiary hospital — so you know exactly where to go, what to expect, and what you're entitled to at every step.

Fundamental Concepts

1. Levels of Healthcare in India (Primary Healthcare)

India's public healthcare system is organised in three tiers, designed to route patients to the right level of care:

Level	Facility	Typical Role
Primary	Sub-Centres, Ayushman Arogya Mandirs (Health & Wellness Centres), Primary Health Centres (PHCs)	First point of contact — common illnesses, maternal/child care, screening
Secondary	Community Health Centres (CHCs), District Hospitals	Specialist consultation, minor surgery, inpatient care
Tertiary	Medical colleges, specialty and super-specialty hospitals	Advanced, specialised treatment and complex surgery

Remember

Starting at the right level — usually a primary health centre first — often gets you faster, more appropriate care than heading straight to a large hospital for routine concerns.

2. Government Hospitals vs Private Hospitals

Aspect	Government Hospitals	Private Hospitals
Cost	Free or heavily subsidised	Paid, often higher cost
Insurance Coverage	Ayushman Bharat and state schemes widely accepted	Accepted at empanelled hospitals; private insurance also common
Waiting Times	Can be longer due to high patient volume	Often shorter, subject to capacity
Availability	Widespread, including rural areas	More concentrated in cities and towns

Tip

Both government and empanelled private hospitals accept Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY — always check empanelment status through the official hospital search portal before assuming a cost.

Complete Detailed Explanation

This section covers the practical systems every citizen should understand.

3. Health Insurance Basics

Health insurance protects against high, unexpected medical costs, regulated in India by the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI).

Term	Simple Meaning
Premium	The amount paid regularly to keep the policy active
Sum Insured	The maximum amount the insurer will pay in a policy year
Cashless Facility	Treatment at network hospitals without upfront payment
Waiting Period	The time before certain conditions become eligible for a claim
Co-payment	A share of the bill the policyholder pays out of pocket

4. Ayushman Bharat (Overview)

Ayushman Bharat is the Government of India's flagship health scheme, with two components working together:

Component	What It Provides
Health & Wellness Centres (Ayushman Arogya Mandirs)	Free primary care, screening, and health promotion close to home
PM-JAY (Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana)	Cashless hospitalisation cover up to ₹5 lakh per family per year

Indian Context

Eligibility is based on SECC 2011 deprivation and occupational criteria — no income certificate is needed. Since October 2024, all citizens aged 70 and above are covered regardless of income. Call the national helpline **14555** for eligibility or hospital queries.

5. Ambulance Services

Number	Service
112	Unified national emergency number
108	Emergency ambulance response in most states
102	Free ambulance service, often prioritising pregnant women and children

Tip

When calling, state your exact location and the nature of the emergency clearly and calmly — this speeds up the response significantly.

6. Blood Donation

Blood donation in India is entirely voluntary and non-remunerated, regulated by the National Blood Transfusion Council (NBTC).

Requirement	Standard
Age	18 to 65 years
Weight	At least 45 kg

Haemoglobin	At least 12.5 g/dL
Frequency	Every 3 months for men, every 4 months for women

> **Tip**
> You can search for nearby blood banks and check stock availability through the government's e-Raktkosh portal.

7. Organ Donation Awareness

Organ donation in India is governed by the Transplantation of Human Organs and Tissues Act (THOTA), 1994, which legalised deceased donation and recognises brain death.

- **Living donation:** Generally restricted to immediate blood relatives, or others with special permission.
- **Deceased donation:** Can provide up to 6 life-saving organs — kidneys, liver, heart, lungs, pancreas, and intestine — plus tissues like cornea and skin.
- **National coordination:** Managed by NOTTO (National Organ and Tissue Transplant Organisation), supported by regional and state-level networks.

> **Remember**
> Even if you've pledged to donate, family consent is still required at the time of donation — it helps to share your decision with them in advance.

8. Patient Rights

India's Charter of Patients' Rights, drafted by the National Human Rights Commission in 2018, sets out rights that every patient is entitled to at any healthcare facility.

- Right to information about diagnosis, treatment, and cost.
- Right to emergency care, regardless of ability to pay.
- Right to informed consent before any procedure.
- Right to confidentiality, privacy, and dignity.
- Right to seek a second opinion.
- Right to transparency in billing and choice of medicines or tests.
- Right to non-discrimination in care.

9. Important Health Helplines

Helpline	Purpose
112	Unified emergency number (police, fire, medical)
108 / 102	Ambulance services
104	General health advisory helpline (availability varies by state)
14416	Tele-MANAS mental health helpline
1800-116-117	National Poisons Information Centre
14555	Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY helpline

1098	CHILDLINE — child helpline

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Empanelled Hospital	A hospital officially registered to provide cashless treatment under a scheme like PM-JAY.
Cashless Treatment	Treatment where the hospital bills the insurer directly, without upfront patient payment.
Tertiary Care	Highly specialised medical care, usually at large hospitals or medical colleges.
Informed Consent	A patient's agreement to treatment after understanding its risks, benefits, and alternatives.
NOTTO	National Organ and Tissue Transplant Organisation, India's apex donation coordination body.
ABHA ID	Ayushman Bharat Health Account — a free digital health record ID for any citizen.

Step-by-Step Understanding

Accessing Care Through Ayushman Bharat, Step by Step

1. **Check eligibility:** Visit the PM-JAY portal or call 14555 to confirm your family's status.
2. **Get your Ayushman Card:** Register using Aadhaar at a Common Service Centre or empanelled hospital.
3. **Find an empanelled hospital:** Use the official hospital search portal before your visit.
4. **Present your card:** An Ayushman Mitra at the hospital will guide you through verification.
5. **Receive cashless treatment:** No upfront payment is required for covered procedures.

Real-Life Indian Examples

Example 1

A daily-wage worker in Varanasi needed emergency gallbladder surgery. Using his Ayushman card at an empanelled private hospital, his family paid nothing out of pocket for a procedure that would otherwise have cost months of income.

Example 2

A college student in Mysuru began donating blood regularly after learning about the 3-month donation cycle, eventually helping a local thalassemia patient who needed repeated transfusions.

Example 3

A family in Ahmedabad, after losing a loved one suddenly, chose to donate his organs after being counselled by a hospital transplant coordinator — saving multiple lives through NOTTO's coordination network.

Example 4

A patient in Chennai, unsure about a suggested surgery, exercised her right to a second opinion under the Patients' Rights Charter before proceeding — and ultimately received a less invasive, equally effective treatment option.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario	What You Should Do
You're unsure if your family qualifies for Ayushman Bharat	Check your status on the PM-JAY portal or call the 14555 helpline.
You need an ambulance urgently	Call 108 (or 102), state your location clearly, and stay on the line.
A hospital asks for payment before emergency treatment	Know that emergency care cannot legally be denied for inability to pay — raise this per the Patients' Rights Charter.
You want to become a blood donor	Confirm you meet the age, weight, and health criteria, then visit a nearby blood bank or camp.
You're considering pledging to donate your organs	Register your intent and, importantly, discuss it with your family in advance.

Government Rules & Guidelines

Body / Scheme	Role
National Health Authority (NHA)	Implements Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY nationwide
National Blood Transfusion Council (NBTC)	Sets standards for safe blood donation and transfusion
NOTTO	Coordinates organ and tissue donation across India
IRDAI	Regulates all health insurance providers in India
National Human Rights Commission (NHRC)	Drafted India's Charter of Patients' Rights

Laws & Policies

The Transplantation of Human Organs and Tissues Act, 1994

This law legalised organ donation from deceased donors, formally recognised brain death, and established a regulatory framework to prevent commercial trading in human organs.

The **Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010** sets minimum standards for hospitals and clinics in adopting states, while the **Charter of Patients' Rights (2018)** consolidates rights previously scattered across the Constitution, the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, and Supreme Court judgments into one accessible reference.

Important Statistics

Statistic	Insight
Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY covers over 12 crore families, with 42+ crore cards issued	One of the largest publicly funded health insurance schemes in the world.

Over 15,000 private hospitals are empanelled under PM-JAY, alongside government hospitals	Gives beneficiaries genuine choice, not just government-only access.
PM-JAY now covers around 1,949 medical procedures cashlessly	Spans everything from common surgeries to cancer care and organ transplants.
Since October 2024, all citizens aged 70+ are covered regardless of income	A major recent expansion protecting senior citizens specifically.

Suggested Visual: A simple flowchart of the 3-tier healthcare system, from Sub-Centre to tertiary hospital.

Best Practices

- Check your family's Ayushman Bharat eligibility today, before you need it urgently.
- Keep a physical and digital copy of your Ayushman Card and ABHA ID.
- Save key ambulance and helpline numbers in every family member's phone.
- Ask questions and seek a second opinion whenever a major treatment is suggested.
- Consider becoming a regular, voluntary blood donor if you're eligible.
- Discuss organ donation wishes openly with your family in advance.

Common Mistakes

- Assuming you're ineligible for Ayushman Bharat without actually checking.
- Not knowing your Patients' Rights, and accepting unclear billing or denied information.
- Pledging organ donation without informing family members.
- Delaying an ambulance call to "wait and see" in a genuine emergency.
- Assuming private care is always better, or government care is always inferior.

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Ayushman Bharat only helps people below the poverty line."	Eligibility is based on specific SECC deprivation/occupational criteria, and all citizens 70+ now qualify regardless of income.
"Private hospitals never accept government health schemes."	Thousands of private hospitals are empanelled under PM-JAY nationwide.
"Hospitals can refuse emergency treatment if you can't pay immediately."	Emergency care cannot legally be denied on this basis.
"Blood donation is unsafe for the donor."	It is safe for eligible, healthy adults following standard NBTC screening.
"Signing an organ donor pledge is legally final, regardless of family wishes."	Family consent is still required at the time of donation in India.

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Check your Ayushman Bharat eligibility proactively	Don't assume you're not covered without checking
Ask for clear information about diagnosis and cost	Don't hesitate to request a second opinion
Save ambulance and helpline numbers in advance	Don't wait until an emergency to look them up
Confirm hospital empanelment before assuming a cost	Don't assume all private hospitals charge the same way
Discuss organ donation wishes with your family	Don't rely on a pledge card alone without family awareness

Safety Tips

- Keep your Ayushman Card, ABHA ID, and insurance documents easily accessible.
- Know your nearest empanelled hospital before an emergency happens.
- Always request a bill breakdown at private facilities if anything seems unclear.
- Verify any organ or blood donation request through official channels only.

Emergency

Dial **112** for unified emergency response, **108/102** for an ambulance, or **14555** for Ayushman Bharat support.

Practical Checklist

Healthcare Readiness Checklist

☐ Checked family's Ayushman Bharat eligibility
☐ Ayushman Card and ABHA ID accessible (physical or digital)
☐ Nearest empanelled hospital identified
☐ Ambulance and health helpline numbers saved
☐ Aware of key Patients' Rights
☐ Family aware of any blood/organ donation wishes

Quick Revision Notes

Revision

- India's healthcare system runs on 3 tiers: primary, secondary, tertiary.
- Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY offers ₹5 lakh/family/year cashless cover; helpline 14555.
- Blood donation: age 18–65, weight 45kg+, every 3–4 months.
- Organ donation is coordinated by NOTTO under THOTA, 1994; family consent is always needed.
- The Patients' Rights Charter (2018) guarantees information, consent, and emergency care.
- Key helplines: 112, 108/102, 14416, 1800-116-117, 14555, 1098.

Key Takeaways

Key Takeaway

1. India's healthcare system offers far more free, structured support than most citizens realise.
2. Ayushman Bharat and government schemes can prevent medical costs from becoming a family crisis.
3. Every patient holds real, government-recognised rights at any healthcare facility.
4. Blood and organ donation are safe, regulated, and genuinely life-saving.
5. Knowing key numbers and entitlements in advance is what makes them useful in a crisis.

Glossary

Empanelled Hospital — A hospital registered to provide cashless treatment under a scheme like PM-JAY.

Cashless Treatment — Treatment billed directly to the insurer, without upfront patient payment.

Tertiary Care — Highly specialised medical care, usually at large hospitals.

Informed Consent — Agreeing to treatment after understanding its risks, benefits, and alternatives.

NOTTO — National Organ and Tissue Transplant Organisation.

ABHA ID — Ayushman Bharat Health Account, a free digital health record ID.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What are India's three levels of healthcare?

Primary, secondary, and tertiary care, ranging from local health centres to specialised hospitals.

2. How much does Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY cover?

Up to ₹5 lakh per family per year for secondary and tertiary hospitalisation.

3. Do I need an income certificate for Ayushman Bharat?

No — eligibility is based on SECC 2011 deprivation and occupational criteria, not income certificates.

4. Are senior citizens covered under Ayushman Bharat?

Yes — since October 2024, all citizens aged 70 and above are covered regardless of income.

5. What is the Ayushman Bharat helpline number?

14555 (also 1800-11-4477).

6. What is the difference between 108 and 102 ambulance services?

108 is the general emergency ambulance response; 102 often prioritises pregnant women and children.

7. Who can donate blood in India?

Healthy adults aged 18–65, weighing at least 45 kg, with haemoglobin of at least 12.5 g/dL.

8. How often can someone donate blood?

Men every 3 months, women every 4 months.

9. What organs can a deceased donor provide in India?

Up to 6 life-saving organs — kidneys, liver, heart, lungs, pancreas, and intestine — plus tissues.

10. Who regulates organ donation in India?

NOTTO, under the Transplantation of Human Organs and Tissues Act, 1994.

11. Does an organ donor pledge override family consent?

No — family consent is still required at the time of donation.

12. What is the Charter of Patients' Rights?

A 2018 NHRC document listing rights every patient holds, including information, consent, and emergency care.

13. Can a hospital deny emergency treatment for inability to pay?

No — emergency care cannot legally be denied on this basis.

14. What does "cashless treatment" mean?

The hospital bills the insurer directly, so the patient doesn't pay upfront.

15. What is IRDAI?

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India, which regulates health insurance providers.

16. What is a "waiting period" in health insurance?

A period before certain conditions become eligible for an insurance claim.

17. How many hospitals are empanelled under PM-JAY?

Over 15,000 private hospitals, in addition to government hospitals nationwide.

18. What is an ABHA ID?

A free, digital health account ID that securely stores an individual's health records.

19. Can I get a second medical opinion under Indian patient rights?

Yes — this is an explicitly recognised patient right.

20. What does NOTTO stand for?

National Organ and Tissue Transplant Organisation.

21. What is the significance of brain death in organ donation law?

Indian law recognises brain death as a legal form of death, enabling deceased organ donation.

22. Which body sets India's blood donation safety standards?

The National Blood Transfusion Council (NBTC).

23. What number should I call for a mental health concern?

Tele-MANAS at 14416, a free 24x7 government helpline.

24. What is the CHILDLINE number?

1098, India's free 24x7 helpline for children in distress.

25. What's the single most useful habit from this handbook?

Checking your family's healthcare entitlements and saving key helpline numbers before you ever need them.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Tables

Flowchart: India's 3-tier healthcare system, from Sub-Centre to tertiary hospital.

Card: Ayushman Bharat eligibility and how to check your status.

Poster: Blood donation eligibility criteria at a glance.

Infographic: Patients' Rights Charter, shown as 7 simple icons.

Table Card: Key health helplines for every household to keep visible.

Official References

- National Health Authority (NHA) — Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY guidelines and eligibility criteria.
- National Blood Transfusion Council (NACO/MoHFW) — blood donor eligibility standards.
- National Organ and Tissue Transplant Organisation (NOTTO) — organ donation framework.
- National Human Rights Commission — Charter of Patients' Rights, 2018.
- Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) — health insurance regulation.
- The Transplantation of Human Organs and Tissues Act, 1994, Government of India.

Official Government Website Links

Resource	Website
Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY	pmjay.gov.in
National Health Authority	nha.gov.in
e-Raktkosh (Blood Bank Portal)	eraktkosh.in
NOTTO	notto.mohfw.gov.in
Ministry of Health & Family Welfare	mohfw.gov.in

Conclusion

India's healthcare system is more accessible and more protective of patients than many citizens realise — but only for those who know it exists. Whether it's a free Ayushman Bharat treatment, a life-saving blood donation, or simply knowing your right to a clear answer from your doctor, this knowledge genuinely changes outcomes.

As you move ahead in the JanGyan platform, use the Practice and Quiz sections to reinforce what you've learned here, and don't hesitate to use AI Assistance whenever a doubt arises. An informed patient is not just better protected — they are an active partner in their own care.

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